

Editorial

Broadband, Narrow Minds

Y“YAHAN PAR HAMARI kahani offbeat ho jaati hai,” said Rajesh Khanna to budding director Asrani while describing a melodramatic movie story in the ever-green comedy Bawarchi. It loosely translates into: “Here is where we have a twist in the tale.”

Any discussion on broadband penetration in India reminds one of this dialogue. Was Rajesh Khanna prescient?

Consider the evidence. First, we had the joke played upon consumers by Internet service providers by categorising 128 Kbps speeds as “lightning speed broadband”. The government finally put paid to these claims by defining broadband as “minimum 256 Kbps of download speed”. Then, the same ISPs began defining their rate cards based on per MB of download, and priced 1 MB at Rs 1.50 if you ever dared to go beyond the specified limit. What they conveniently hide from customers is that they will charge fees based on data transfer—so technically, both uploads and downloads will be charged. Be that as it may, consumers in India still welcomed the “broadband revolution”.

But it is at this juncture that the story turns offbeat. The success of broadband in India does not depend on the government opening up bandwidth. Nor does it depend upon the investments and marketing campaigns by Internet Service Providers. And it certainly does not depend upon consumers (those measly, low-life scum).

It all depends, ladies and gentlemen, on your local cable operator. Only if the mighty Multi-System Operator (or MSO; an MSO is a super cable operator like InCable, or Hathway) deems fit, will you get a broadband connection. This is because the MSO itself has an interest in the lucrative broadband business.

Here is how it works: Most broadband Internet connections are given using the cables already laid by the cable operator. The cable operator cannot provide any broadband connection if the ISP does not have a signed agreement with the MSO. So, suppose your MSO has no infrastructure to provide you a broadband connection, but intends to give it in, say, six months' time, we wish you the very best of luck. He will not allow any other ISP to use his cables to give you a broadband connection. For instance, if you stay in an InCable “territory”, and you want a Hathway, Sify, or



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an Iqara connection, you will have to wait until InCable builds its own broadband infrastructure.

The options are to a) wait; or b) work with your 56 Kbps modem.

Evidently, the trouble with technology penetration in India is not that people don't want to spend—it is that there are too many hurdles to spend that money. The sooner the authorities realise this, the faster we can progress. And yes, we sure don't need another twist in the tale, do we?

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